

Heavy losses: After losing the finals in the Australian and French Opens this year, Sabalenka was under immense pressure. AFP

Gauff in the French Open final. In her semifinal against Anisimova, during an 18-point game serving at 4-5, the Belarusian double-faulted to lose the opening set 6-4. Sabalenka, who hadn't lost a match in straight sets at a Major since the 2020 US Open, fought back. Screaming, as she threw her body into every shot, she won the second set 6-4.

With Sabalenka serving at 4-5 in the deciding set, both had won 104 points. Anisimova earned three match points, leading love-40. Sabalenka staved off the first two. But Anisimova belted a bold forehand crosscourt winner to clinch the 6-4, 4-6, 6-4 triumph. Sabalenka, who converted only three of 14 break points, admitted, "I should have been a little more brave today." However, she showed more grace in defeat than she did after losing to Gauff five weeks earlier. "She was the better player. Losing sucks. You feel like you want to die."

Bencic (**right, below**), the singles gold medallist and doubles silver medallist at the Tokyo Olympics, edged 18th-seeded Ekaterina Alexandrova 7-6(4), 6-4 in the fourth round. Bencic, who won the junior title here in 2013, said, "I'm happy I'm here to live the dream." She then upset 7th-seeded Mirra Andrejeva 7-6(3), 7-6(2) to advance to her second Major semifinal.

Laura Siegemund, who had never advanced past the second round at Wimbledon, conjured the biggest upset against Australian Open champion and sixth-seeded Keys. Before The Championships, Keys said, ironically, "I've always loved playing on grass. It just makes sense for my game." Not against undersized (5'6"), ageing (37), much lower-ranked (No. 104) Siegemund, though. The German veteran, known more for her doubles success, had never gone past the Wimbledon second round before. Nonetheless, Siegemund stunned Keys 6-3, 6-3. With a masterly array of drop shots,

stinging and touch volleys, extremely low slices, occasional powerful groundstrokes, accurate lobs, and splendid defence, Siegemund disrupted and defused the power game of the discombobulated Keys, eliciting a torrent of forced and unforced errors. It was a tactical masterpiece reminiscent of long shot Roberta Vinci's shocking upset of Serena in the 2015 US Open semifinals. Siegemund almost pulled off an even bigger upset against Sabalenka when she led 4-3, 40-30 in the deciding set of the most intriguing quarterfinal. But power

ultimately overcame finesse, and Sabalenka prevailed 4-6, 6-2, 6-4. The often volatile Belarusian said, "I'm really proud of the way I handled my emotions out there."

In the final, after a flawless performance, Swiatek fell on her back, a la Bjorn Borg, the stoic Swede who introduced that victory gesture when he won his first Wimbledon in 1976. Swiatek is now the eighth woman to capture Grand Slam singles titles on all three surfaces, joining Evert, Martina Navratilova, Hana Mandlikova, Graf, Serena, Maria Sharapova, and Barty.

